

Andre Forbes

AI & Technology Advisor | Wealth Management and FinTech Domain Expert | Agentic AI, Salesforce FSC, Cybersecurity, and Enterprise Integration

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Hands-on technology advisor and builder with 17 years of experience and a continuous advisory track record spanning Gearbox Solutions (2014 to 2022, embedded on-site across 200+ clients in media and entertainment, healthcare, consumer goods, construction, hospitality, and creative production) through to the founding of Aplodex (May 2026, an independent AI and IT advisory practice serving wealth management and financial services firms). Between those two advisory chapters, served as the sole technology authority at Balentine, a \$9B+ AUM SEC-registered RIA, progressing from IT Manager to Director of Technology, Architecture, and AI: no CIO above, no peer on technology, full ownership of every architectural, security, vendor, and AI decision, and direct quarterly briefings to the Chairman and Managing Board. The result is an advisor who has already done the work he advises on, at production scale, in a regulated financial services environment, and across dozens of unrelated client industries.

Deepest domain is wealth management and financial services. At Balentine, built the entire technology function from scratch after the prior outsourced program failed an SEC cybersecurity examination: rebuilt on a NIST CSF and CIS Controls foundation, passed the next SEC exam with zero findings, and then layered the firm's agentic AI platform on top of that secure base. Salesforce FSC is the central nervous system of that build: sole owner of all administration, development, and architecture across five production packages totaling approximately 963 Apex classes, 134+ LWC components, 98 active Flows, and 21 Apex triggers. Every custodian feed (Pershing, Fidelity, Addepar, RedBlack, Arch), every advisor workflow, and every AI output routes through Salesforce as the system of record. Delivered approximately \$7M in total quantified value including \$950K in hard savings, roughly \$2M in avoided outsourcing costs, and roughly \$4M in productivity gains across the firm.

Production agentic AI depth is a primary differentiator. Architected and shipped an 11-server Model Context Protocol (MCP) estate exposing 425+ governed tools across Salesforce, Addepar, Pershing, Arch, Box, Gong, Zoom, Microsoft Graph, RedBlack, Fidelity, and Rippling, with Salesforce as the central data hub into which all external systems feed and from which all agents read context and write outputs. Runs 195GB of self-hosted LLM inference on-premises (deepseek-r1:70b, qwen3:30b, Qwen 3.6 27B, Gemma 4 31B, gpt-oss:120b, llama3.2-vision) with runtime provider switching to the Claude API. Multi-tier RAG over Qdrant vector search and a PostgreSQL cache holding 7M+ transactions delivers sub-second answers. Also designed Panorama, an enterprise AI architecture for a \$24B+ RIA spanning 55 offices and 415 employees, covering tiered agent access models, on-prem inference, phased rollout governance, and a distributed-workforce adoption framework.

Technology breadth spans the full stack that enterprise technology leadership requires. Cybersecurity and governance: NIST CSF, NIST AI RMF, CIS Controls, SOC 2 vendor review, HIPAA-aligned data handling, SEC exam readiness, authored the firm AI Policy and a four-layer AI Governance Framework (strategy, risk, operational controls, trust and compliance), built a unified Security and Network Monitoring Dashboard aggregating 10+ integrated security systems into a single operational picture. Cloud and infrastructure: Azure, Entra ID, Microsoft Intune MDM, two-office network design (HP core switching, Cisco Meraki, Cisco vMX virtual routers, site-to-site VPN). Platform and integration: Microsoft 365 digital workplace end-to-end (Exchange Online, Teams, SharePoint, OneDrive, Microsoft Graph), enterprise GenAI rollout (ChatGPT Enterprise, Claude Enterprise, Microsoft 365 Copilot with tenant-level governance and conditional access), API pipelines across 20+ vendor platforms with 60+ automated sync jobs, and a 14-application internal web-app fleet on Express.js, PostgreSQL, React, and nginx. Speaks on industry panels at Salesforce and T3 conferences on data orchestration, fintech integration, and agentic architecture.

Carries all of this depth into the Aplodex advisory practice today: advising wealth management and financial services clients on AI strategy, agent design, model and platform selection, integration architecture, and responsible-AI governance across Google Vertex AI, AWS Bedrock, and Azure AI Foundry, wiring agentic workflows into the portfolio management, custodial, GRC, and productivity platforms clients already run. The advisory identity is not new: it was established at Gearbox in 2014, proven at enterprise scale at Balentine from 2022 through 2026, and is now the core of Aplodex. Builder, strategist, and advisor in one seat.

EXPERIENCE

Founder and Principal

May 2026 - Present

Aplodex (AI and IT Advisory), Atlanta, GA (Remote)

- Founded an independent AI and IT advisory practice serving wealth management and financial services clients. Advise on AI strategy, agent design, model and platform selection, integration architecture, and AI governance for firms standing up agentic AI across their existing technology stacks.

- Design and train AI agents on the major enterprise AI platforms (Google Vertex AI, AWS Bedrock, Azure AI Foundry): select the right model and grounding approach per use case, build the prompt, retrieval, and tool-calling patterns, and stand up the evaluation and guardrail layers that make agents safe to deploy in a regulated financial services environment.
- Architect cross-platform agentic workflows that connect enterprise AI platforms to clients' wealthtech, custodial, and compliance systems (portfolio management, custody, and GRC platforms) and to their internal productivity stacks (Google Workspace, Microsoft 365, Salesforce), so intelligence flows into the systems of record advisors and operations teams already work in rather than living in a separate tool.
- Bring a builder's depth to the advisory work: the same hands-on Salesforce architecture, custom MCP server engineering, multi-provider LLM routing, and self-hosted inference experience built solo at a \$9B+ RIA, now applied across multiple client environments and cloud platforms.
- Help clients establish responsible-AI governance for financial services: data classification, model approval workflows, prompt-injection mitigation, audit logging, and tiered agent access aligned to NIST AI RMF and SEC expectations.

Director of Technology, Architecture, and AI

Jan 2026 - Apr 2026

Balentine, Atlanta, GA

- Promoted to own the firm's AI agenda, architectural standards, and evolution into an agent-first operating model on top of the technology foundation already built. Owned AI strategy, the agentic platform, Salesforce architecture, firm-wide technology roadmap, and the technology budget end-to-end. Delivered quarterly briefings to the Chairman on technology posture and AI roadmap; presented directly to the Managing Board on all technology, AI, and risk matters. C-suite operating cadence and executive accountability at a 65-person, \$9B+ AUM SEC-registered RIA.
- Founded and built the firm's agentic AI unit, a self-hosted production agent platform architected with Salesforce as the central data hub: 11 MCP servers exposing 425+ tools across Salesforce, Addepar, Pershing, Arch, Box, Gong, Zoom (183 tools), Microsoft Graph, RedBlack, Fidelity, and Rippling. Agents read client, account, opportunity, transition, RMD, and capital call records from Salesforce as the authoritative source and write activity timeline entries, AI-summarized notes, classification updates, and follow-up tasks back to Salesforce so advisor work product lands in the CRM as the canonical record. Orchestrator plus 11 specialist agents plus a Senior RIA Advisor reviewer agent. Runtime LLM provider switching between local Ollama (qwen3:30b, Qwen 3.6 27B, Gemma 4 31B, gpt-oss:120b, deepseek-r1:70b, llama3.2-vision, bge-m3 embeddings, approximately 195GB of on-prem models) and the Claude API. Multi-tier RAG over Qdrant vector search plus a PostgreSQL cache holding 7M+ transactions for sub-second answers.
- Sole Salesforce owner end-to-end: administration, development, architecture, and AI. Owned all admin (users, profiles, permission sets, sharing rules, page layouts, record types, validation rules), all development (approximately 963 Apex classes, 134+ LWC components, 98 active Flows, 21 Apex triggers across 5 production packages: TeamDashboard, AI Activity Timeline, Client Risk Manager, Client Transition Manager, and Pershing Custodian Integration), and all architecture (Salesforce DX multi-package source control, sandbox strategy, deployment pipelines, integration patterns, data model evolution, Lightning Data Service usage at scale). No outsourced Salesforce dev team.
- Built the firm's Salesforce AI layer end-to-end: a custom Salesforce MCP server exposing 41 governed tools over OAuth 2.1 (the largest and most-invoked of the 11 servers), Salesforce Agentforce integrations (custom actions wired to Apex invocable methods and Flow-based actions, bridge patterns between on-platform Agentforce agents and the external MCP-orchestrated agent estate), Salesforce Data Cloud for off-platform API integrations (REST and bulk API connectors, identity unification, calculated insights, lineage and access boundaries for governed agent retrieval), Salesforce CRM Analytics (Einstein Analytics) dashboards across all firm data, and AI Activity Timeline (61 Apex classes powering an AI-summarized cross-source activity feed embedded directly inside Salesforce).
- Led a five-person functional team: one direct report (IT Support Associate) plus four dotted-line and matrixed reports (Salesforce administrator, client service associate, project manager, and associate relationship manager). Built and managed a dedicated Salesforce delivery team: hired and onboarded a Salesforce Administrator to own day-to-day admin operations and a Project Lead / Associate Relationship Manager for business-side requirements gathering, project intake, and stakeholder coordination. Retained architecture, development, and AI ownership on top.
- Daily-driver AI-native builder using Claude Code, OpenAI Codex, and Cursor to ship production code at multiples of solo-builder velocity. The 11-MCP-server agentic platform, the 14-app internal fleet, the 5-package Salesforce build (approximately 963 Apex classes and 134 LWCs), and all AI-driven internal products were written and iterated through these tools. Operates fluently with agents and sub-agents, authors custom skill (.md) files for repeatable workflows, and orchestrates multi-agent coding pipelines for complex refactors.
- Designed Panorama, an enterprise AI architecture for a \$24B+ RIA spanning 55 offices and 415 employees: tiered agent access models, on-prem inference, phased rollout governance, and an adoption framework built for distributed workforces (design engagement, not deployed).
- Built the firm's AI governance framework: usage policies, data classification standards, model approval workflows, prompt-injection mitigations, audit logging, and tiered agent access patterns aligned to NIST AI RMF and CIS Controls. Authored the firm's AI Policy as a standalone governing document.
- Rolled out ChatGPT Enterprise, Claude (Anthropic) Enterprise, and Microsoft 365 Copilot at team and enterprise scope: license procurement, usage governance, security and data-handling policies, integration with internal AI workflows, and structured adoption training. Copilot deployed through the Microsoft 365 suite (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, Teams) with tenant-level governance and conditional access aligned to firm AI usage standards.
- Built the Insights App, an AI meeting intelligence and call analytics platform with voice profiles ('sound like me') that capture how individuals communicate, pulling from Gong, OpenAI, and the Salesforce MCP to give advisors usable signal from every recorded conversation.
- Constructed a unified Security and Network Monitoring Dashboard aggregating live posture across 10+ integrated systems (Huntress EDR, SentinelOne, Cisco Umbrella, Cisco Meraki, NinjaOne, Microsoft Graph identity and sign-ins, MS Defender, SSL certificate health, Box security events, Rippling user activity, and Gong and DocuSign audit feeds). Eight-domain tabbed interface with unified alert feed, cross-system correlation, composite security score, and built-in pen testing and security scanner. Replaced ten separate vendor portals with one operational picture.

- Run quarterly innovation cycles to evaluate emerging AI platforms and build-vs-buy decisions; benchmarked Snowflake vs. Databricks across AI speed, usability, and cost. Speak on industry panels at Salesforce and T3 conferences about data orchestration, fintech integration, and agentic architecture.

Director of Information Technology

Jul 2024 - Jan 2026

Balentine, Atlanta, GA

- Founded the firm's internal technology function at a \$9B+ AUM SEC-registered RIA. Inherited a failed outsourced MSP program that had produced recent SEC cybersecurity exam findings. Took sole ownership of cybersecurity, infrastructure, identity, cloud, data orchestration, Salesforce, and platform development end-to-end. Defined the build-not-buy operating model that every system in the firm runs on today.
- Brought cybersecurity in-house and rebuilt on a NIST CSF and CIS Controls foundation. Passed the next SEC examination with zero cybersecurity findings. Established a SOC 2 vendor review process: validated SOC 2 and SOC 2 Type II attestations for all critical software providers and used the reports to drive third-party risk decisions.
- Hired and managed an IT Support Associate as a direct report: scoped the role, ran the search, onboarded, set objectives, ran 1:1s, and built a tier-one support layer that freed architecture, AI, and strategic platform capacity.
- Engineered automated data orchestration pipelines syncing holdings, balances, transactions, tax lots, RMDs, contributions, beneficiaries, billing assignments, and entity hierarchies across Addepar, Pershing, and Salesforce: 5,000+ accounts with concurrent processing, exponential backoff, and automated Salesforce record creation for net-new accounts.
- Led custom Salesforce FSC buildout (Apex, LWC, SOQL) using Salesforce DX with multi-package source control: 191 Apex classes, 68 LWC components, 98 active Flows, and 21 Apex triggers in the TeamDashboard package alone. Engineered bidirectional sync between Salesforce, Addepar, Pershing, and internal apps to create a unified client data layer. Delivered the TeamDashboard advisor experience with 7 main tabs, 7 embedded sub-dashboards, a proprietary Client Complexity Score, a cross-source Activity Timeline, and Conga Orchestrate integration for new-account workflows.
- Engineered the firm's deep Pershing custodian Salesforce integration suite: 677 Apex classes, 53 LWC components, and 6 triggers covering account hierarchy, asset registration mapping, multi-document reconciliation, and bidirectional sync with cert-authenticated Pershing APIs. The largest Salesforce package in the firm's stack.
- Designed, built, and deployed 10+ production web applications (budget, projects, value cards, documents, onboarding, upload, pre-meeting and discovery, insights, rewards, SSO) on a unified stack: Express.js, PostgreSQL 14 (200+ tables), React 18 with Tailwind v4, nginx with 22 domain configs, and PM2 process management with launchd-managed restart-on-boot, all hosted on a single Mac Mini server alongside 8 MCP servers, Keycloak SSO, and Redis.
- Built and managed API pipelines integrating 20+ vendor platforms (Addepar, Pershing, Salesforce, Box, Rippling, Microsoft Graph, Gong, Zoom, HubSpot, Twilio, NinjaOne, Huntress, Cisco Meraki and Umbrella, Keeper, KnowBe4, eMoney, and more) with 60+ automated sync jobs running nightly and intraday.
- Owned the firm's Microsoft 365 digital workplace ecosystem end-to-end: Exchange Online, Teams, SharePoint, OneDrive, Microsoft Graph integrations, Entra ID identity, conditional access policies, license management, and Microsoft Intune MDM across iOS, iPadOS, Android, and Windows endpoints. Stood up Keycloak as a SAML Identity Provider federated with Rippling for single sign-on across all internal apps.
- Owned the firm's RedBlack trading platform end-to-end: imports and exports of trade data, backend integration with Salesforce, Pershing, and Fidelity, daily archival, FIX protocol feeds, and out-of-par variance handling. Migrated RedBlack from on-prem to AWS (Cisco vMX virtual router, site-to-site VPN, FIX protocol routing) with continuous trading-platform availability through cutover. Led the firm-wide Pershing-to-Fidelity custodian conversion, including a custom SFTP ingestion server on DigitalOcean (file watcher, SQLite intake schema, 14 PostgreSQL tables, 18 daily jobs) feeding directly into Salesforce.
- Selected and rolled out enterprise platforms that replaced fragmented tooling: Addepar (portfolio reporting and billing of record), Gong (revenue intelligence and call coaching), Rippling (consolidated HCM, payroll, benefits, and device management), and Dispatch (data orchestration backbone). Owned vendor selection, contracting, integration architecture, and adoption for each.

IT Manager

Sep 2022 - Jul 2024

Balentine, Atlanta, GA

- Ran daily IT operations across infrastructure, networking, cloud systems, and enterprise applications while leading the turnaround of an underperforming outsourced environment, diagnosing gaps in security, reliability, and vendor performance to prepare for full internalization.
- Started rebuilding the cybersecurity program: implemented improved endpoint controls, tightened identity governance, enforced security baselines, and established early NIST-aligned processes that became the foundation for the SEC exam turnaround.
- Implemented a cost-effective hardware purchasing strategy that reduced equipment spend by 30%. Consolidated 12 disparate employee systems into a single platform (Rippling), streamlining onboarding, payroll, benefits, and device management.
- Built out IT infrastructure (MDF, networking, AV, and endpoint setup) for a new office location in Raleigh, NC. Managed IT support across multiple geographically distributed sites (Atlanta, Raleigh, Baltimore, Kansas, and remote workers) delivering consistent service levels remotely.
- Built early versions of the automation and integration pipelines that later became core to the firm's enterprise data strategy. Led IT support and operations staff, coached junior team members, and set the culture of ownership and communication that carried into the Director roles.

IT Consultant

Sep 2014 - Sep 2022

Gearbox Solutions (IT Consulting Firm), Atlanta, GA

- Eight-year embedded IT consulting tenure across a 200+ client portfolio spanning media and entertainment, consumer goods (Coca-Cola), healthcare (HIPAA-aligned data handling, ePHI access controls), construction, travel and hospitality, and creative production. Two primary long-running engagements anchored the work: on-site IT Manager at Cartoon Network / Turner Studios (daily) and on-site IT Manager at Finished Art (weekly). This is the origin of the advisory track record now formalized as Aplodex: walking into unfamiliar client environments, owning their technology end-to-end, and delivering across wildly different industries for nearly a decade.
- Embedded directly inside client sites and owned their day-to-day technology as if internal staff: server environments, deployment pipelines, endpoint management, identity and access (AD/OD, Okta SSO, Exchange/IMAP, SMB/AFP/NFS, VPN, firewalls), and network operations across the multi-industry client base. Used Jamf Pro for macOS MDM (configuration profiles, app deployment, compliance baselines, zero-touch provisioning) and ServiceNow for ITSM workflows (ticket management, change requests, incident response).
- Supported healthcare clients with HIPAA-aligned data handling, ePHI access controls, secure deployment, and audit-friendly logging, cross-regulatory experience complementing the SEC compliance work later performed at Balentine.
- Acted as a trusted technical advisor to client leadership across all engagements: scoped needs, made build-vs-buy recommendations, mentored client-side and Gearbox engineering teams, and translated technology decisions for non-technical stakeholders. The same consulting muscle now central to the Aplodex advisory practice.

IT Manager (via Gearbox Solutions)

Sep 2014 - Sep 2022

Cartoon Network / Turner Studios (TBS, TNT, CNN, Adult Swim), Atlanta, GA

- Served as the on-site IT Manager for Cartoon Network / Turner Studios for eight years as a primary Gearbox consulting engagement: owned server administration, identity and access, networking, software deployment, and day-to-day support for production, creative, and business teams at one of the largest cable networks in the US.
- Managed and contributed to the development of Mesmo, a media project-management and cross-team approval platform that routed broadcast content through review and sign-off across production, creative, standards, and scheduling teams before it aired. Owned day-to-day platform operations and coordinated the multi-team approval workflow that gated on-air media.
- Managed the macOS and Windows fleet via Jamf Pro (configuration profiles, app deployment, MDM enrollment, compliance baselines) with Okta SSO for federated access across studio business applications. Built internal tools, deployment systems, and automation scripts that streamlined high-velocity media and broadcast production workflows.

IT Manager (via Gearbox Solutions)

Nov 2014 - Jun 2021

Finished Art, Inc., Atlanta, GA

- Served as the on-site IT Manager for Finished Art, a creative and design studio serving advertising, brand, and packaging design clients: owned Apple-first infrastructure, enterprise Mac management via Jamf Pro, identity, networking, and end-user support for designers and production staff.
- Built internal tools and workflow automation supporting complex creative production pipelines: high-resolution asset workflows, render-farm coordination, and deadline-critical client deliverables.

IT System Support Professional V, TSS Apple Administrator

Dec 2007 - Aug 2014

Kennesaw State University, Kennesaw, GA

- Led Apple enterprise support across one of the largest public universities in Georgia: deployment, imaging, automation, device management, and lab infrastructure for 400+ machines serving students, faculty, and research staff.
- Designed and maintained macOS desktop and laptop environments across student computer labs, faculty offices, and research workstations. Built FileMaker-based internal tools and provided L3 support. FERPA-aware data handling for student records across academic and administrative departments.
- Mentored junior team members who later moved into leadership roles.

EDUCATION

Master of Science, Management Information Systems

2013 - 2015

Kennesaw State University

Bachelor of Science, Health Science

2005 - 2009

Kennesaw State University

CORE SKILLS

- Wealth Management and FinTech: SEC-regulated RIA operations, Salesforce FSC (Apex, LWC, Flows, Agentforce, Data Cloud), custodian integrations (Pershing, Fidelity, Addepar, RedBlack, Arch), portfolio data orchestration, and digital transformation for \$9B+ AUM environments
- FinTech Platforms and Integrations: enterprise API pipelines across 20+ vendor platforms (Addepar, Pershing, Gong, Rippling, Box, Zoom, Microsoft Graph, HubSpot, Twilio, SAP Concur, QuickBooks), 60+ automated sync jobs, and FIX protocol routing for trading platform migrations

- Agentic AI and LLM Engineering: 11 production MCP servers, 425+ governed tools, multi-agent orchestration, on-prem LLM inference at 195GB (deepseek-r1:70b, qwen3:30b, Gemma 4 31B, gpt-oss:120b, llama3.2-vision), multi-tier RAG over Qdrant and PostgreSQL (7M+ transactions), runtime LLM provider switching
- Cybersecurity and Compliance: NIST CSF, CIS Controls, SEC cybersecurity examination readiness (zero findings), SOC 2 Type II vendor review, HIPAA-aligned data handling (ePHI access controls), AI Policy authorship, and unified Security and Network Monitoring Dashboard across 10+ integrated security systems
- Cloud and Infrastructure: Azure (Entra ID, hosted domain controllers), AWS (RedBlack migration, Cisco vMX, site-to-site VPN), DigitalOcean (SFTP ingestion server), Google Vertex AI, AWS Bedrock, Azure AI Foundry, multi-cloud AI platform selection and agent deployment
- Salesforce Platform Architecture: Salesforce DX multi-package source control (5 production packages, approximately 963 Apex classes, 134+ LWC components, 98 Flows, 21 triggers), Salesforce Agentforce (custom actions, Apex invocable methods, Flow-based actions), custom MCP server (41 tools, OAuth 2.1), Salesforce Data Cloud (REST and bulk API connectors, identity unification, calculated insights), Salesforce CRM Analytics (Einstein Analytics)
- Technology Leadership and Advisory: sole technology authority at a \$9B+ RIA (board briefings, budget ownership, vendor selection and contracting), 200+ client advisory engagements via Gearbox Solutions (2014 to 2022), Aplodex founder-principal (2026 to present), direct and matrixed team leadership (hiring, performance objectives, cross-functional alignment), iterative delivery across 14 production applications and 15 platform domains, CoP Design for AI and Salesforce communities of practice
- Generative AI Strategy and Governance: enterprise rollout of ChatGPT Enterprise, Claude Enterprise, and Microsoft 365 Copilot; NIST AI RMF-aligned AI governance framework; four-layer responsible-AI policy (strategy, risk, operational controls, trust and compliance); prompt-injection mitigation and tiered agent access design
- Identity, Access, and Governance: Entra ID, Keycloak SAML IdP, Okta SSO, Microsoft Intune MDM (iOS, Android, Windows, macOS), conditional access policies, Jamf Pro (macOS MDM, zero-touch provisioning), and enterprise identity governance across regulated multi-office environments
- On-Premises and Network Infrastructure: Cisco Meraki, Cisco vMX virtual routers, HP core switching, site-to-site VPN, two-office network design, Secur and Avigilon Alta physical access control, production Mac Mini server stack (nginx 22-domain config, PM2, PostgreSQL, Redis, Keycloak, 14 web apps, 11 MCP servers)
- Enterprise Platform and Digital Workplace: Microsoft 365 end-to-end (Exchange Online, Teams, SharePoint, OneDrive, Microsoft Graph, Entra ID), Google Workspace, full-stack web application development (Express.js, React 18, Tailwind v4, PostgreSQL, nginx, Redis, Socket.IO), AI-pair-programming at production scale (Claude Code, OpenAI Codex, Cursor)
- Quantified Business Impact: approximately \$7M total value delivered at Balentine (\$950K hard savings including \$450K MSP elimination, \$350K Salesforce dev team replacement, and \$150K infrastructure optimization; roughly \$2M in avoided outsourcing; roughly \$4M in productivity gains), 30% hardware cost reduction, 5,000+ account orchestration pipeline, and industry panel speaker on agentic architecture and fintech integration